

Removing An Elder

*The Most Difficult Act of Church Leadership — Done
Biblically*

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Removing An Elder

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REMOVING AN ELDER

THE MOST DIFFICULT ACT of Church Leadership — Done Biblically

Pastors Connection Network

pastorsconnectionnetwork.com

Introduction: The Conversation No One Wants to Have

THIS BOOK EXISTS BECAUSE of a gap in pastoral literature that corresponds to a gap in pastoral practice.

There are books about how to find and install elders. There are books about how to develop elder teams and how to navigate elder conflict. But very few books address the moment when all of that has failed — when an elder can no longer serve in the role, when the qualification has been lost, when the pattern of behavior has become damaging enough that the congregation needs to be protected from the man who was installed to protect it.

The gap in the literature mirrors the gap in practice. Most elder removals are handled poorly. They happen too slowly because the pastor or elder team was unwilling to initiate the conversation. They are communicated too vaguely because no one wanted to be specific about what had happened. They

This book is an attempt to fill both gaps. Not to make elder removal seem easy or routine — it is neither. But to give the pastors and elder teams who face this situation a biblical framework for understanding why it is sometimes necessary, a practical process for executing it with care, and the pastoral wisdom to navigate the aftermath in a way that serves the congregation's health rather than compounding its pain.

One more word before we begin. The removal of an elder is an act of love — love for the congregation that the elder is no longer serving well, love for the broader church whose witness depends on its leaders being genuinely qualified, and ultimately love for the elder himself, who needs the truth about his current state more than he needs the protection of his title. This framework will try to keep that love in view throughout, because the act will only be done well when it is motivated by genuine care for everyone involved and not merely by institutional necessity.

Do not admit a charge against an elder except on the evidence of two or three witnesses. As for those who persist in sin, rebuke them in the presence of all, so that the rest may stand in fear. — 1 Timothy 5:19–20

CHAPTER ONE

Why Removing an Elder Is So Difficult

THE REAL REASONS WE wait too long and the cost of waiting

There is an elder in your church right now who should not be an elder.

That sentence will land differently depending on your specific situation. For some pastors, it is immediately recognizable — there is a face that comes to mind, a pattern of behavior that has been concerning for months, a situation that has been quietly festering while you have been hoping it would resolve on its own. For others, the sentence produces a more diffuse unease — the sense that something is not right, that the standard is not being met, without a specific enough picture to know where to begin.

Whatever your situation, the reason you have not yet acted on what you know is almost certainly one of a small set of recognizable reasons. Not cowardice, exactly. Not incompetence. But a set of very human, very understandable

THE RELATIONAL COST

THE FIRST REASON IS relational. If the elder who needs to be removed is a man you have known for years, prayed alongside, disagreed with and reconciled with, served shoulder-to-shoulder in the trenches of congregational ministry — the prospect of being the one who initiates his removal is not merely institutionally difficult. It is personally painful.

Elder relationships are among the most significant in a pastor's ministry. They carry the weight of shared calling, shared sacrifice, and shared history. To move from that kind of partnership to the formal process of removal is to make a shift so severe that most pastors will find nearly any alternative preferable. They will give the elder another chance. They will reframe the concerning behavior as a temporary difficulty. They will tell themselves that the situation is improving when the evidence does not support that conclusion. They will do almost anything to avoid the conversation they know they need to have.

This is understandable. It is also a failure of pastoral leadership. The relational cost of elder removal is real. But the cost of not acting when action is required — to the congregation, to the church's witness, and ultimately to the elder himself — is consistently greater.

THE CONGREGATIONAL DISRUPTION

THE SECOND REASON IS the anticipation of congregational disruption. Removing an elder is never

This anticipation is not irrational. The disruption is real, and it will require significant pastoral investment to address. But the pastor who avoids elder removal in order to avoid congregational disruption is making a calculation that protects the congregation's short-term peace at the cost of its long-term health. A congregation that is led by an unqualified elder is a congregation whose spiritual welfare is being compromised. The disruption of a necessary removal is temporary. The damage of an unnecessary retention is cumulative.

THE UNCERTAINTY OF PROCESS

A THIRD REASON PASTORS delay is genuine uncertainty about how to proceed. What does the process look like? What authority does the elder team have to remove one of its members? What is the congregation's role? What should be communicated, to whom, and when? These are legitimate questions, and the absence of clear answers to them is a genuine obstacle to action.

This is one of the specific gaps this book is designed to fill. The uncertainty of process should not be an obstacle to necessary action. It should be a prompt to develop a clear process before the situation arises, so that when it does, the team is not making it up under pressure.

NONE OF THE REASONS for delay — relational cost, anticipated disruption, process uncertainty — outweigh the cost of the delay itself. That cost is specific and serious.

The congregation is being led by a man who is no longer qualified for the office. Whether the disqualification is moral, doctrinal, or character-based, the congregation is receiving leadership from someone who, by the church's own stated standard, should not be providing it. Every week this continues is a week the congregation's spiritual care is being compromised.

The elder team's culture is being shaped by the tolerance of the pattern. When an elder team observes that one of its members is behaving in ways that would disqualify a candidate from installation, and does nothing, the team communicates to itself and to the congregation that the standard is negotiable. That message is extraordinarily difficult to walk back.

And the man himself is being harmed. The elder who needs to be removed and is not being removed is not being protected. He is being enabled. The kindest thing the pastor and elder team can do for a man who has fallen below the qualification standard is to tell him the truth, quickly and clearly, so that he has the opportunity to repent, to seek restoration, and to deal honestly with the situation rather than continuing in a role that his current condition does not support.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What is the specific reason you have delayed having the elder removal conversation you know needs to happen? Is

REMOVING AN ELDER

What is the cost to your congregation of every additional week that an unqualified elder remains in office? Have you calculated that cost honestly?

Does your church have a clear, agreed-upon process for elder removal before a specific situation arises? If not, what would it take to develop one?

Who would hold you accountable to initiate a necessary removal conversation if your own reluctance was preventing you from acting?

CHAPTER TWO

Biblical Grounds for Elder Removal

WHAT THE SCRIPTURE SAYS and how it applies

Elder removal is not merely a governance decision. It is a theological one. And the theological grounding for it matters, both for the integrity of the process and for the pastoral communication that must accompany it.

The grounds for elder removal fall into three broad categories in the New Testament: moral failure, doctrinal deviation, and character disqualification. Each category requires its own assessment process, its own timeline, and its own specific form of pastoral communication. Understanding the distinctions between them is the foundation of a biblically faithful removal process.

MORAL FAILURE

SEXUAL SIN IS THE most commonly cited basis for pastoral and elder removal, and for good reason. The “husband of one wife” qualification and the broader

But moral failure encompasses more than sexual sin. Financial dishonesty — fraud, theft, deceptive business practices, the exploitation of the church’s members for personal financial gain — is an equally serious basis for removal. Paul’s explicit qualification that the elder be “not a lover of money” is not merely a preference. It is a requirement. The man whose financial integrity has been genuinely compromised is not qualified to exercise oversight of a community’s spiritual and material resources.

Abuse of authority — the use of pastoral or elder power to control, intimidate, or harm those in the elder’s care — is also moral failure. This category is increasingly recognized in evangelical church culture as a serious form of pastoral misconduct, and rightly so. The elder who uses his spiritual authority to create dependence, to suppress legitimate concerns, or to harm the people he is supposed to protect has violated the fundamental character of the office.

The Difference Between a Single Failure and an Established Pattern

Not every moral failure is grounds for immediate, permanent removal. The gospel is a gospel of repentance and restoration, and the elder qualification standard, as we have argued in the preceding books of this series, is not a standard of sinless perfection but of credible, genuine character.

The distinction that matters is between a single failure that has been genuinely repented of and addressed, and an

This distinction is not a loophole. It is a pastoral recognition that the standard the office requires is about who the man genuinely is, not about whether he has ever failed. But applying it requires honest, careful assessment rather than either reflexive disqualification or reflexive minimization. The elder team that is genuinely trying to honor both the standard and the gospel will sometimes find this distinction difficult to apply. That difficulty is appropriate. It reflects the genuine pastoral weight of the decision.

DOCTRINAL DEVIATION

PAUL'S INSTRUCTION IN TITUS 1:9 that the elder must “hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught” is not merely a positive requirement. It is a standard by which the elder's fitness for continued service can be evaluated. An elder who has moved away from the church's confessional commitments in ways that are significant and sustained has lost a qualification the office requires.

What constitutes significant doctrinal deviation? This requires the kind of theological discernment that cannot be reduced to a formula. The elder who has begun to question a

The operative question is not “Does this elder agree with everything the church teaches?” — genuine theological integrity requires the freedom to hold and express honest questions. The operative question is “Is this elder able and willing to hold firm to and defend the trustworthy word as this church has received and confessed it?” When the honest answer to that question is no, the doctrinal dimension of the teaching qualification has been lost.

CHARACTER DISQUALIFICATION

THE THIRD CATEGORY IS the most complex to adjudicate and the most frequently neglected: the ongoing character pattern that constitutes a loss of the elder’s qualification even in the absence of a specific moral failure or doctrinal deviation.

The elder whose anger is no longer manageable, whose contempt for those who disagree with him has become visible and regular, whose personal relationships are consistently leaving damage in their wake — this elder has not committed a specific act of misconduct. But the pattern of his behavior reflects a condition of character that is incompatible with the qualifications the office requires. He is no longer “above reproach.” He is no longer “gentle, not quarrelsome.” He is no

Character disqualification is the most difficult basis for removal because it requires the most honest assessment of pattern rather than incident, and because the man himself will often dispute the assessment. He may acknowledge specific incidents while rejecting the characterization of them as a pattern. He may describe his behavior as appropriate responses to genuinely difficult provocations rather than as ongoing character failures. And the elder team must be prepared to hold the assessment with both gentleness and firmness in the face of that dispute.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Of the three categories — moral failure, doctrinal deviation, and character disqualification — which is most relevant to any current situation you are navigating? What specific evidence supports the assessment?

How does your elder team apply the distinction between a single failure and an established pattern? Is the distinction being used with integrity, or has it been used to minimize patterns that deserve to be taken more seriously?

What is your church's governance document's provision for elder removal? Does it address all three grounds, or does it focus only on moral failure?

Is there an elder whose character pattern has been gradually disqualifying for months or years without being directly addressed? What has prevented the conversation?

CHAPTER THREE

The Process: Before You Move Formally

PRIVATE CONFRONTATION, DOCUMENTATION, AND elder team engagement

The removal process should almost never begin with a formal action. It should begin with a conversation — a direct, private, honest conversation between the pastor or the lead elder and the elder whose fitness for the office is in question.

This is the Matthew 18 principle applied to leadership: before institutional action, relational confrontation. Before formal process, personal engagement. The purpose is not to delay the inevitable — if the situation genuinely warrants removal, the private conversation will not prevent it. The purpose is to honor the relationship, to give the man in question the respect of being spoken to directly rather than being acted upon institutionally, and to allow the possibility of genuine repentance and response before the more severe consequences of formal action are engaged.

THE PRIVATE CONFRONTATION SHOULD be initiated by the senior pastor or by the most senior elder on the team — the person whose relationship with the affected elder is both most significant and most structurally appropriate for this kind of conversation. It should be a genuine confrontation, not a performance of concern that is designed to satisfy the Matthew 18 requirement without actually engaging it. And it should have specific, clear content.

The specific content of the confrontation will depend on the basis for the potential removal. If the basis is moral failure, the confrontation names the specific behavior that has been established: “I need to speak with you directly about something serious. I have learned that [specific description of behavior]. I am bringing it to you privately first because our relationship and your integrity both deserve that. I want to hear your response.” If the basis is character disqualification, the confrontation names the specific pattern: “I need to talk with you about a pattern of behavior that has been visible over the past [time period]. I have observed [specific examples]. This pattern raises serious questions for me about your ability to continue serving as an elder. I want to engage that directly with you before taking any other steps.”

What you are listening for in the response is the presence or absence of genuine repentance and genuine engagement with the substance of the concern. Genuine repentance is specific — it acknowledges the specific behavior or pattern named, takes responsibility for it without deflecting to extenuating circumstances, and expresses a genuine intention to change. Genuine engagement is honest — it may

The absence of genuine repentance or genuine engagement does not end the process. It defines the next step.

DOCUMENTATION

ONE OF THE PRACTICAL disciplines that pastors frequently neglect in situations that may develop into removal processes is documentation. The instinct is understandable — documentation feels clinical and adversarial in a pastoral relationship. But the failure to document is a significant error that becomes evident when the formal process requires evidence of what was said, when, and with what response.

Documentation does not require formal memoranda or legal-style records. It requires a simple, consistent practice of writing down, after each significant conversation or observation, what was discussed, what was said, and what the response was. Date and time. The substance of the conversation. The specific words used by both parties, as best as they can be remembered. Any commitments made. Any next steps agreed to.

This practice protects the pastor and the elder team from selective memory — the very human tendency to remember conversations in ways that support our preferred narrative of what happened. It protects the elder being evaluated from the equally human tendency to have his behavior assessed more harshly than the facts support. And it provides the factual foundation that a formal removal process will need in order

INVOLVING THE ELDER TEAM

IF THE PRIVATE CONFRONTATION does not produce genuine engagement with the concern, the next step is to bring the situation to the full elder team. This is both the Matthew 18 principle — if the private conversation does not resolve the issue, involve additional witnesses — and a recognition that the removal of an elder is too significant an action to be taken unilaterally.

The elder team conversation should be conducted with the same specificity as the private confrontation. Not “I have some concerns about [name]’s fitness for the office” — that is too vague to produce productive engagement. But a specific account of what has been observed, what the private confrontation revealed, and what the team is now being asked to discern together.

The elder team’s role at this stage is both discernment and support. Discernment: is the concern well-founded? Does the team’s broader observation of the man in question support the pastor’s assessment? Are there additional concerns the team is aware of that have not yet been raised? And support: the pastor who has had to initiate this process is carrying a significant weight, and the elder team’s genuine engagement is one of the most important forms of support it can provide.

The elder team conversation should conclude with a specific decision: is the team agreed that the concern is sufficiently founded to proceed to a formal removal process? If yes, what is the process and who is responsible for each step? If no, what additional discernment is needed before that decision can be made?

Have you had the private confrontation that the situation requires? If not, what specific thing is preventing you from initiating it?

Are you currently documenting significant conversations and observations related to a potential removal situation? If not, what would it take to establish that practice immediately?

Has the elder team been appropriately involved in the discernment process? Are they aware of the full picture, or is the situation being managed unilaterally?

What does genuine repentance look like in your specific situation? What would you need to observe, and over what period of time, before you would be confident that the repentance is genuine?

CHAPTER FOUR

The Formal Removal Process

MOVING FROM DISCERNMENT TO action

The formal removal process begins when the private confrontation and elder team engagement have confirmed that the situation requires a formal response. This is the point at which the process shifts from pastoral conversation to institutional action — a shift that should be made deliberately, with full awareness of the seriousness of what is being done.

The formal process must accomplish three things: it must protect the integrity of the decision by ensuring it is well-founded and fairly made, it must protect the dignity of the elder being removed by treating him with the honesty and respect his personhood deserves, and it must protect the congregation by ensuring that necessary information is communicated clearly and that the transition is managed with appropriate pastoral care.

THE FORMAL PROCESS SHOULD begin with a written statement of concern — a document prepared by the senior pastor and the elder team that describes, in specific terms, the basis for the formal removal consideration. This document is shared with the elder being considered for removal. It is not a verdict. It is a formal articulation of the concern that provides the foundation for the final conversation and the elder's opportunity to respond.

The written statement should include the specific behavior, pattern, or doctrinal position that is the basis for the concern; the specific examples and evidence that support the assessment; a description of the prior private confrontation and its outcome; and a clear statement of what the process will be from this point forward, including the timeline and the opportunity for the elder to respond.

The written statement is important for several reasons. It ensures that the elder knows exactly what he is being accused of — there are no ambiguous or moving targets. It provides a clear foundation for the final conversation that cannot be later recharacterized as having been about something different. And it gives the elder the opportunity to prepare a genuine, thoughtful response rather than being ambushed in a formal meeting.

THE RESPONSE PERIOD

AFTER RECEIVING THE WRITTEN statement, the elder should be given a defined period — typically one to two weeks — to prepare and offer a response. This response may take any form: a written reply, a meeting with the

What happens during the response period often determines whether the formal process concludes with removal or with a restored qualification. The elder who responds to the written statement with genuine repentance, specific acknowledgment of the behavior or pattern named, and a credible account of the concrete steps he is taking to address it — this response warrants genuine reconsideration. The removal process is not designed to produce a predetermined outcome. It is designed to produce the truth about the elder's current condition. And if the truth, honestly assessed, is that genuine repentance is occurring and the qualification is being restored, the process should reflect that.

The elder whose response defends, deflects, or counter-attacks without genuine engagement with the specific concerns has provided the elder team with important information about his current condition. The absence of genuine engagement is itself a form of response.

THE FINAL CONVERSATION AND DECISION

THE FINAL CONVERSATION BETWEEN the elder team and the elder being considered for removal is the most significant meeting in the process. It should be conducted with care, with clarity, and with genuine pastoral intent toward the man in the room, even though its outcome may be his removal from a role he has held for years.

The conversation should begin with the elder team

The team's decision should be made transparently in the conversation — not reserved for a subsequent private meeting. The elder being evaluated deserves to hear the team's assessment of his response and the team's decision in the same conversation, rather than waiting for a communication that comes later. This is a matter of basic pastoral respect.

If the decision is removal, the communication should be clear and specific. "The elder team has considered your response carefully. Based on [specific assessment], we have concluded that you no longer meet the qualifications for the elder office. We are recommending your removal from the elder team effective [date]." The language should be neither harsher than the situation requires nor softer than honesty permits.

THE CONGREGATIONAL DIMENSION

PAUL'S INSTRUCTION IN 1 Timothy 5:20 is direct: elders who persist in sin are to be rebuked before all, so that the rest may stand in fear. This is not a comfortable text. But it is an important one, because it makes clear that the congregation's knowledge of significant elder discipline is not merely permitted but required in certain cases.

Not every elder removal requires a full public disclosure of the details. The removal of an elder for a relatively private

But the removal of an elder for public sin — particularly sin that has directly affected members of the congregation, or sin that is already known within the congregation, or sin that involves the abuse of the elder's authority over congregation members — requires a more direct congregational communication. The congregation that is protected from information it needs in order to understand what has happened is not being cared for. It is being managed. And the congregation that learns what actually happened from a source other than its leadership is a congregation whose trust in that leadership has been significantly damaged.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Does your church have a formal elder removal process — including a written statement of concern and a defined response period — already in place? If not, when will you develop one?

How will you determine how much to communicate to the congregation about the basis for a specific removal? What principle will guide that decision?

How will you protect the dignity of the elder being removed in the formal process, even while being clear about why the removal is necessary?

What is your plan for the final conversation? Who will be present, who will speak, and how will the decision be communicated?

CHAPTER FIVE

Pastoral Care During and After Removal

CARING FOR THE ELDER, the congregation, and yourself

The removal decision is not the end of the pastor's responsibility. It is, in some ways, the beginning of a new phase of pastoral work — one that requires sustained attention to the elder being removed, to the congregation processing the transition, and to the pastor's own soul under the weight of one of ministry's most difficult experiences.

CARING FOR THE ELDER BEING REMOVED

THE ELDER BEING REMOVED is still a person with a soul. This should not need to be said, but in the institutional dynamics of a removal process it is easy to lose sight of. The formal actions — the written statement, the final meeting, the congregational communication — can create a distance that feels appropriate given the seriousness of the situation but that can become a failure of pastoral care if it hardens into permanent relational

The care the pastor offers the departing elder will be shaped by the specific situation. In a case of genuine moral failure where the elder has not repented, pastoral care looks like honest compassion: “I still care about you as a person. I am praying for your repentance and restoration. And I have to be clear that the restoration of your standing before God must come before any conversation about restoration to ministry.” In a case of character disqualification where the elder believes the assessment was unfair, pastoral care looks like honest engagement: a willingness to hear the elder’s perspective, to acknowledge the painful nature of the process, and to maintain the relationship with appropriate boundaries even in the face of the elder’s anger or hurt.

The pastor’s specific responsibilities to the departing elder include: ensuring that the written and verbal communication of the removal was specific, honest, and fair; ensuring that the elder’s spouse and family are cared for by someone with the relational standing to provide that care; and maintaining a genuine posture of prayer for the elder’s healing, repentance where needed, and long-term restoration.

WHAT RESTORATION LOOKS LIKE — AND WHEN

ONE OF THE MOST important — and most misunderstood — distinctions in the aftermath of elder removal is the distinction between restoration to fellowship and restoration to the office. These are different things. They happen on different timelines. And conflating them produces some of the most painful and

Restoration to fellowship is the church's welcome of a genuinely repentant person back into full community life. It includes the forgiveness of the congregation and the relational acceptance of the person. It is available to every genuinely repentant person, including the elder who was removed for moral failure or character disqualification.

Restoration to the office of elder is a different matter. It requires not just repentance but the restoration of the qualifications that were lost. Depending on the specific situation, that restoration may require months or years of sustained behavioral change, accountability, and demonstrated growth. In some cases — particularly those involving severe moral failure or abuse of authority — the pastoral wisdom of the church may be that restoration to leadership in the same context is not appropriate, even where genuine repentance has occurred.

The pastor who communicates clearly and early about this distinction is sparing both the church and the departing elder enormous confusion. “You are still welcome here, and we will walk with you through this. But the path back to the elder office, if that path is ever appropriate, will be a long one that looks like genuine, sustained, observable change over time.”

CARING FOR THE CONGREGATION

THE CONGREGATION WILL FEEL an elder removal, even when it does not know all the details. People who have been cared for by the departing elder will feel his absence. People who are loyal to him may be angry or confused. And the congregation's trust in its leadership — including its trust in the senior pastor — will be shaped by how the

The most important pastoral contribution the senior pastor can make in the aftermath of an elder removal is consistent, honest, theologically grounded preaching and presence. Not explaining the situation from the pulpit in detail — that is rarely the appropriate venue. But modeling, through the consistency of his own pastoral engagement, that the church's leadership can be trusted to make difficult decisions, to handle them with integrity, and to continue shepherding faithfully through the disruption.

Individual conversations — particularly with the members who were closest to the departing elder — are also essential. Not to provide information that should not be shared, but to provide pastoral presence and honest care. “I know this is disorienting. I want you to know that I care about [name], and I also care about you. I’m not able to share all the details, but I can tell you that this decision was made carefully and prayerfully. And I’m here if you need to talk.”

CARING FOR YOUR OWN SOUL

THE PASTOR WHO HAS just removed an elder — who has had the confrontational conversations, written the statement, conducted the final meeting, and communicated to the congregation — needs pastoral care himself. Not eventually. Now.

The emotional weight of elder removal is significant. The grief of a damaged or ended pastoral friendship. The anxiety of congregational response. The self-doubt about whether the process was handled correctly. The spiritual burden of having exercised authority in a way that has caused real pain to a real person, even when it was necessary. All of this is real,

The pastor needs people outside the congregation who can hear and hold the full weight of the experience — a trusted pastoral friend, a coach, a counselor, a PCN cohort partner. Not to second-guess the decision, necessarily, but to provide the human companionship and spiritual support that the process requires. And the pastor's own soul care — prayer, Scripture, sabbath, honest community — must be given specific attention in the weeks following a removal, because the depletion the process produces is real and must be addressed.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What does genuine pastoral care for the departing elder look like in your specific situation? What are you responsible for, and what are the appropriate limits of your engagement?

Have you communicated clearly about the distinction between restoration to fellowship and restoration to the office? Is there clarity in the congregation about what those two different paths look like?

Who in the congregation most needs a direct pastoral conversation in the aftermath of this removal? When will you have it?

Who is caring for you through this process? Do you have someone outside the congregation to whom you can bring the full weight of this experience?

CHAPTER SIX

What This Reveals and What to Build After

USING A DIFFICULT SEASON as an invitation to structural and cultural improvement

Every elder removal is both an ending and a beginning. The ending is obvious: a tenure of service has concluded, a relationship has been significantly damaged or ended, and a season of congregational disruption has been navigated. But the beginning is equally real. The removal has surfaced something about the church's leadership culture, its accountability structures, and its qualification processes that, addressed honestly, can produce significant and lasting improvement.

The pastor and elder team that emerges from a removal process without examining what it revealed has missed one of the most important opportunities that difficult seasons provide. The examination is not comfortable. But it is essential.

ALMOST EVERY ELDER REMOVAL raises a question about the selection process that produced the man being removed. Not as an accusation — the process may have been as careful as the church knew how to make it at the time. But as an honest inquiry: what did the selection process miss, and why?

Sometimes the answer is that the concern was genuinely invisible at the time of installation. Moral failure that develops after an elder is installed cannot be retrospectively blamed on the selection process. Character patterns that were genuinely latent rather than visible cannot be expected to have been surfaced by even the most careful evaluation.

But sometimes the answer is more uncomfortable. The selection process did not include a spouse conversation that would have surfaced the concerning pattern. The doctrinal assessment was perfunctory and did not probe the theological drift that eventually became significant. The above-reproach standard was assessed against the man's public presentation rather than his private life. The financial integrity qualification was assumed rather than investigated. Something that a more thorough process would have found was not found because the process was not thorough enough.

This is not an occasion for self-recrimination. It is an occasion for improvement. The specific gap that the removal revealed should become the specific improvement that the revised selection process includes.

WHAT ELDER REMOVAL REVEALS ABOUT THE ACCOUNTABILITY CULTURE

an elder removal often reveals something about the elder team's accountability culture — specifically, how well the team provides ongoing accountability to its members after they have been installed.

The elder whose moral failure developed over years without anyone noticing or addressing it was failing in ways that a genuine accountability culture would have surfaced. Not through surveillance — but through the kind of regular, honest, specific pastoral conversation that asks the hard questions and expects honest answers. “How is your marriage?” “How are you doing with the temptations that have historically been difficult for you?” “Have there been any significant concerns about your behavior that you are aware of?”

These conversations are uncomfortable. They require the kind of mutual vulnerability that institutional elder relationships rarely produce unless they are deliberately cultivated. But they are also the most effective early-warning system available. The elder who is honest in these conversations when the concern is small produces the opportunity for address and correction long before the concern grows to the point of requiring formal action.

The team that builds this kind of accountability culture — not as a surveillance program, but as a genuine expression of pastoral care for each other — will not eliminate the need for elder removal. But it will dramatically reduce the frequency and severity of the removals it requires.

BUILDING THE STRUCTURES THAT PREVENT THE NEXT CRISIS

improvements

most commonly indicated by elder removal are: a more thorough qualification assessment in the selection process, a regular accountability structure within the elder team, and a clear removal process documented in the church's governance materials.

The qualification assessment improvement is specific to the gap the removal revealed. If the removal surfaced a pattern that a spouse conversation would have found, require the spouse conversation for every future candidate. If it surfaced doctrinal drift that a more thorough theological assessment would have identified, build that assessment into the standard process. Specific improvements to specific weaknesses are more effective than general commitments to “do better.”

The accountability structure should be built into the elder team's regular rhythm rather than reserved for crisis moments. An annual confidential self-assessment, in which each elder honestly evaluates his own fitness against the biblical qualifications, combined with a direct conversation with a designated accountability partner, provides ongoing visibility into the condition of each elder's qualification. This is not a burden. It is a gift — the gift of a community that cares enough about its leaders to ask the hard questions on a regular basis rather than waiting for a crisis to make them unavoidable.

The removal process documentation ensures that the church has a clear, agreed-upon process before the next situation arises. This documentation should describe the grounds for removal, the process for initiating and conducting it, the authority structure within which decisions

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What specific gap in your selection process did this removal reveal? What improvement will you make in response?

What does your current elder team's accountability culture look like? Is anyone asking the hard questions on a regular basis, or are accountability conversations reserved for crisis moments?

Does your church's governance documentation include a clear elder removal process? If not, what is the plan for developing one?

What is the most important thing you have learned from this experience that you want to carry forward into the next season of your elder team's life?

Conclusion: The Courage That Love Requires

THIS HAS BEEN A hard book to read. It is a harder reality to live. The removal of an elder — the confrontational conversations, the formal process, the congregational disruption, the damaged relationship, the grief of a pastoral friendship that has been irreparably altered — is genuinely among the most difficult things a pastor will ever do.

But the difficulty is not a reason to avoid it when it is necessary. It is a reason to do it well.

The courage that elder removal requires is not a cold institutional courage. It is the pastoral courage that comes from love — love for the congregation that needs to be protected, love for the church's witness that needs to be maintained, and love for the elder himself who needs the truth more than he needs the title. That kind of courage is not

CONCLUSION: THE COURAGE THAT LOVE REQUIRES

Do not be afraid of this work. Be honest about its cost. Be careful about its execution. Be pastoral in its communication. And trust that the God who called you to this responsibility will provide what it requires.

Be watchful, stand firm in the faith, act like men, be strong. Let all that you do be done in love. — 1 Corinthians 16:13–14

Act like men. Let it be done in love.

That is the whole of it.

Appendix: Elder Removal Decision Framework

A ONE-PAGE ASSESSMENT FOR Pastors and Elder Teams

Use this framework when evaluating a potential elder removal situation. Complete it prayerfully and with specific, honest answers.

STEP 1: ESTABLISH THE SPECIFIC CONCERN

Write out the specific behavior, pattern, or doctrinal position that is the basis for your concern. Be as specific as possible.

Identify which biblical qualification or qualifications the concern implicates (above reproach, husband of one wife, self-controlled, able to teach, etc.).

List the specific evidence: dates, incidents, observations, and what was said and by whom.

STEP 2: ASSESS THE SEVERITY

Is there evidence of genuine repentance, or has the behavior continued after being identified?

Is the congregation being actively harmed or at risk of harm from this elder's continued service?

STEP 3: ASSESS YOUR PRIOR ENGAGEMENT

Have you had a direct private conversation with the elder about this concern? If so, what was his response?

Has the elder team been informed and engaged with this concern? What was the team's assessment?

Has documentation been maintained of the prior conversations and observations?

STEP 4: MAKE THE DECISION

Based on the above assessment, does the situation warrant formal removal proceedings? (Yes / No / More discernment needed)

If yes: who will initiate the process, what is the timeline, and who is responsible for each step?

If more discernment needed: what specific additional information is required, and who will gather it by when?

STEP 5: PLAN THE PASTORAL CARE

Who will care for the elder being removed during and after the process?

Who will care for the elder's spouse and family?

What will be communicated to the congregation, by whom, and when?

Who is caring for you and the remaining elder team through this process?